

The Boston Globe

Serving our community since 1872

THURSDAY, JULY 17, 2025

Trump takes another tack in bid to oust Powell

Floats fraud claim over renovation of Fed HQ

By Jim Puzzanghera
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — President Trump has long made his displeasure with Federal Reserve Chair Jerome Powell clear.

In response to the Fed's refusal to lower interest rates, Trump has publicly derided Powell as a "knucklehead" and a "dummy" among other insults. But he hasn't fired Powell over that because he can't. The head of the independent

► **Hassett reportedly the early front-runner to replace Powell next year. D1.**

central bank can only be fired for cause.

Now, White House officials might have found something they believe would qualify as cause: the ballooning cost of renovating and expanding the Federal Reserve's Washington, D.C., headquarters.

With estimates of the ongoing project reaching \$2.5 billion or higher, Trump and other White House officials have accused Powell of mismanagement and wasting money on what critics have compared to the Palace of Versailles and the Taj Mahal.

"It's possible there's fraud involved with the \$2.5, \$2.7 billion renovation," Trump said Wednesday after a CNBC report said he was likely to fire Powell soon.

Trump maintained he is "highly unlikely" to fire Powell, whose term as chair doesn't expire

POWELL, Page A6

Healey and donor make a pitch for beach access

Critics question motives

By Matt Stout
GLOBE STAFF

Governor Maura Healey is resurrecting a proposal at the center of a long-running legal dispute between wealthy property owners on Martha's Vineyard that, if passed, could redefine when a beach in Massachusetts is considered public.

Healey tucked the measure into a \$3 billion environmental bond bill she filed last month, using language that mirrors a proposal long pushed by Richard Friedman, a colorful developer and Healey donor who's slated to host a fund-raiser for her this weekend at his Edgartown home.

Friedman for years has battled his neighbors in court over access to a stretch of barrier beach separating Oyster Pond in Edgartown, where he bought property four decades ago, from the Atlantic Ocean on the island's southern shore.

He has also pushed a legislative proposal that would declare that a barrier beach that literally moves — whether by erosion, storms, or rising sea levels — into a publicly owned pond

BEACH ACCESS, Page A10

Shocking loss brings change



PHOTOS BY JESSICA RINALDI/GLOBE STAFF

A makeshift shrine has appeared at Gabriel House in Fall River. Nine of the 69 residents inside when the fire broke out died.

Memories of lives cut short run deep

By Claire Thornton, John Hilliard, and Spencer Buell
GLOBE STAFF

and Ava Berger
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

FALL RIVER — For Eleanor Willett, the Gabriel House was supposed to be her safe harbor — a place she could stay comfortable while keeping family close.

For nearly a year, it was.

Her daughter swung by several times a week. Willett took Ubers to family gatherings that spanned generations. And on Sunday, she spent the day enjoying a visit with her 5-year-old great-great-grandson, whom she adored.

Just hours later, a fire tore through the assisted living home. She and eight others died in the blaze.

The tragedy has left family members stunned. Willett had chosen the place because it was cheaper than other assisted living facilities in the area, and left her with more flexibility to enjoy life. She decorated her space with an Afghan scarf and a bright pink floral bedspread, and liked that she didn't need to use stairs.

"That's why this is so baffling. She was there to be kept safe so nothing would happen to her," said Holly Mallowes, her granddaughter.

VICTIMS, Page A7



A HARROWING NIGHT

'Nine lives were not able to be saved. But that number should have been four to five times that.'

FALL RIVER FIRE CHIEF JEFFREY BACON

Fall River to add firefighters after tragedy

By Nick Stoico and John Hilliard
GLOBE STAFF

and Ava Berger
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

FALL RIVER — City officials pledged Wednesday to hire more firefighters amid criticism that inadequate staffing compromised the response to the deadly fire at an assisted living facility on Sunday.

Meanwhile, the fire chief described the blaze that killed nine residents of the facility, called Gabriel House, as "accidental."

At the time of the fire, two of the 10 fire trucks in Fall River were staffed with a minimum of four firefighters. But Mayor Paul Coogan said city officials discussed staffing with the firefighters union and determined an additional four trucks would now have a minimum of four firefighters.

"So instead of having two trucks at the minimum stan-



At Catholic Charities in Fall River, Nina Amaral of New Bedford sorted through donations for the victims.

dard by the fire safety commission, we're going to go to six," Coogan said at a news conference.

Fire Chief Jeffrey Bacon said the new positions would be filled immediately with overtime shifts, and the department will hire 15 to 20 additional fire-

fighters over the next two years. Bacon said the city will now have 38 firefighters working each shift, an increase from 35.

On Tuesday, Bacon responded to the union's assertion that higher firefighting staffing levels would have saved more lives

FIRE, Page A7



JOHN TLUMACKI/GLOBE STAFF

MAKING A SPLASH

Wednesday was another sizzler, hitting 95 degrees in Boston, but 4-year-old Jesalyz Hardy stayed cool at the Ryan Spray and Wading Pool in Mattapan.

President Trump lashed out at his own supporters, accusing them of being duped by Democrats over the Jeffrey Epstein investigation. **A2.**

Massachusetts led a coalition of states in suing the Trump administration for cutting a grant program that funds disaster preparedness infrastructure. **B1.**

The downed cable that suspended Blue

Line service was probably over 50 years old, MBTA officials said. **B1.**

At least 21 people were killed in a crowd crush and stampede at a Gaza aid distribution center run by the US- and Israeli-backed Gaza Humanitarian Foundation. **A4.**

With another day off for the red-hot Red Sox, it's time to take stock. A review of the first half, **C1.**

Developer of huge project keeps pressure on Brookline

By Andrew Brinker
GLOBE STAFF

On a low-slung stretch of Route 9 in Brookline near the border with Newton, a mostly vacant office park may soon give way to one of the biggest developments in the town's history.

Brookline officials have called the 5.4-acre site in Chestnut Hill an opportunity to create a commercial center, and developer City Realty, which purchased the site last year, presented a vision for exactly that: a new mixed-use complex with a hotel and condominium building as tall as 20 stories, including 215,000 feet of retail space, and nearly 600 units of housing.

But the sheer scale of the proposal has set off alarm bells among neighbors, and approvals have stalled amid deliberations over how much height and densi-

ty might be acceptable at the site. So last week, City Realty launched a backup plan: The developer filed to develop the project under Massachusetts' Chapter 40B housing law, which would allow it to build housing there without approval from the town, as long as 25 percent of it is affordable.

A 40B of this scale would be a drastic step, especially in a town with a recent history of 40B developments that some residents loathe, and the developer emphasized it is still focused on pushing the mixed-use proposal through normal city permitting. But it was a signal that City Realty will not wait for years for Brookline — which is notoriously slow when it comes to approving development — to bless a project that would be among the biggest ever in the town of

BROOKLINE, Page A10

VOL. 308, NO. 17

*

Suggested retail price
\$4.00



Unsticking point

Thursday: Humid, T-storms.
High 85-90. Low 72-77.

Friday: Much drier.
High 83-88. Low 62-67.

Weather and Comics, D5-6.
Obituaries, C9.